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NEWSPAPER

25th January, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

4th WEEK



KURDS, KURDISTAN & TURKEY

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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS ... DISCUSSION

25th JANUARY, 2018

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Towards an endgame?

Turkey makes a decisive move against Kurdish fighters on the border with Syria



VIJAY PRASHAD

On January 20, Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan announced that Turkish forces alongside the Free Syrian Army had begun armed operations in the Syrian town of Afrin, to be followed by a push in Manbij. Turkish aircraft are bombing the city as Turkish and allied forces have moved across the border.

Turkey has long threatened to enter Syria and clear out the forces of the U.S.-backed Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF). The SDF was created in 2015 by the various Syrian Kurdish political forces and their military wing, the People's Protection Units (YPG), and the Women's Protection Units (YPJ). The Syrian Kurds made a political decision that they would not have the ability to properly confront the Islamic State (IS) in northern Syria without an alliance with other minority groups (Assyrians, for instance) – and with the major Sun-

ni tribes in the region (the Shammars, for instance). The SDF was created as a platform for the Syrian Kurds to join with these other groups into an anti-IS military alliance. But, to the Turks, it has always been clear that the SDF is dominated by Syrian Kurds, and is therefore essentially a Kurdish project.

Heart of the conflict

The war to defeat the IS at Raqqa, the major city in northern Syria, could not have been conducted by the U.S. and Russia and their various allies entirely from the air. It required a partner on the ground. The Turkish army was not willing to enter Syria to battle the IS. The Syrian Arab Army was then engaged in operations towards the west and the south of the country. It did not have troops to move towards Raqqa. For that reason, the U.S. government made an arrangement with the SDF to provide it close air support as SDF forces moved across the Syria-Turkish border. The SDF, with air support from the U.S., routed the IS from Raqqa in mid-October 2017. The Syrian-Kurdish leadership suggested that Raqqa's people could join the Kurdish-run Democratic



Federation of Northern Syria, commonly known as Rojava.

The term "Rojava" reveals what is at the heart of the conflict. It means "Western Kurdistan" and asserts the ambitions of the Kurdish population towards the region as well as for a future independent Kurdish state that would encompass land in Iraq (Eastern Kurdistan) and Turkey (Northern Kurdistan). The attempt by Iraqi Kurds in 2017 to declare independence was curtailed for now by the armed intervention of the Iraqi army into the Kurdish autonomous region. The attempt by Syrian Kurds to produce a similar autonomous region on the Syria-Turkish border raised hackles in Ankara.

Turkey sees all Kurdish ambitions for self-determination as an abomination. It has declared the instrument for these ambitions within Turkey, the Kurdish Workers' Party (PKK), as a terrorist or-

ganisation. The war against Turkish Kurds continues in south-eastern Turkey, with curfews in Kurdish towns and with Kurdish political parties effectively banned. The war against the PKK has spilled over into Iraq and Syria, where the Turkish air force has routinely bombed PKK- and PKK-affiliated camps.

To confuse matters, it was the PKK that helped Syrian Kurds develop the YPG, which was the basis for the SDF. The U.S., following its NATO partner Turkey, had declared the PKK as a terrorist organisation. But, confounded by a lack of a ground army in Syria, the U.S. allied with the SDF in the war against the IS. Turkey, at that time, grumbled but did not act to stop the alliance. The U.S. had few choices. But now, with the IS largely defeated and with the U.S. a flickle ally to Syrian Kurds, the Turkish armed forces have made their move.

Abandonment

Turkey has not acted alone as Mr. Erdoğan sought assurances from all the major players in northern Syria before he sent in his troops. The U.S. betrayed its Syrian Kurdish allies when U.S. Secretary of

State Rex Tillerson said that the U.S. does not propose to form a permanent border force in the north manned by the SDF. The Russians withdrew their forces from the region as the Syrian Arab Army, dependent on the Russians, gave assurances that it would not contest the Turkish invasion. There is no one to stop the Turkish entry into Syria and no one to provide Syrian Kurds with assistance. The Turkish air force continues to bomb SDF positions without challenge. The Syrian Kurds do not have a chance.

Turkish tanks have moved swiftly through Afrin's Shera and Shera districts, with YPG and YPJ fighters trying their best to hold off the ground assault. Turkey's total domination of the air over these border towns will give its ground troops a decisive advantage against Syrian Kurds. Protests inside Turkey against this intervention will have little impact. Nor will there be anyone willing to go to the United Nations to ask Turkey to call off its war.

Vijay Prashad is the Executive Director of Trócaire Institute for Social Research

More fire

Turkey's offensive against Kurdish militants on the Syrian border could spin out of control

Turkey's military intervention in the Syrian border town of Afrin against Kurdish militants is a grim reminder of the complexities of the seven-year-long Syrian civil war. The Kurdish People's Protection Units (YPG) played a crucial role in the battle against the Islamic State, ousting it from eastern Syria late last year. In the war, the U.S. provided air cover to YPG-led troops, while the Syrian army and Russia avoided directly clashing with them. But once the IS threat receded, the old geopolitical calculations returned, with Turkey, facing Kurdish militancy at home, turning against Syrian Kurds. Ankara has been warning against empowering Kurdish militants. It sees the Syrian YPG as a vassal of the Kurdistan Workers Party (PKK), the main insurgent group battling government troops in south-east Turkey. Now that the fight against the IS is virtually over, or at least for now, Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan is concerned that the YPG, with renewed battlefield experience and weapons supplied by the West, could offer support to the PKK. When the U.S. announced plans to create a 30,000-strong Kurdish border force, an alarmed Turkey announced the offensive in Afrin. The plan is to oust YPG guerrillas from the town and hand it over to Turkish proxies. From Afrin, they could move to other cities now held by the YPG.

Mr. Erdoğan would like to create a buffer between Turkey and Syrian Kurdistan. There is a convergence of interest among Russia, Syria, Iran and Turkey in the Afrin assault. Mr. Erdoğan sent troops into Afrin only after getting Russian assent. For Russia, which is at present bombing rebel/jihadist positions in Syria's Idlib, Turkish cooperation is needed to continue the mission and it will turn a blind eye to the Afrin attack. For Syria and Iran, which see Kurdish militants as separatists and potential threats, the assault is a blessing in disguise. Yet, despite the tacit regional support Turkey now enjoys, the attack could prove counterproductive. First, the U.S. has been completely sidelined in the operation. If the rift between the U.S. and Turkey, both NATO allies, keeps widening over Syria, the proxy battles in the country could acquire their own momentum. Second, the YPG has proved its worth in the ground battles against the IS since 2015. It is not a fragile militia group that can be pushed over easily with a ground offensive. Besides, the YPG has enormous local support in Kurdish towns along the border. Third, even if Turkey ousts the YPG from Afrin, it won't ease tensions on the border. Rather, it would drag Turkey deeper into the Syrian conflict. This means that Syria's border region, which is among the hardest-hit by the civil war, is likely to see more bloodshed and destruction in the coming months, if not years, unless all countries involved in the conflict change course from war to talks.



2 Towards an endgame? - Vijay Prashad

THE HINDU
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UPSC CSE – GS III

GS III ... TERRORISM

IMPORTANT QUESTION

ESSAY/ MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

After the defeat of the Islamic State, Kurds demand for separate State (Kurdistan) may come to the forefront in West Asia. Examine the issue in totality.

DEMAND FOR KURDISTAN





Recep Tayyip Erdoğan
President , Turkey



NEWS REPORT

- Turkish President announced that Turkish Forces alongside the Free Syrian Army had begun armed operations in the Syrian town of Afrin, to be followed by a push in Manbij.
- It wants to clear the forces of U.S. backed Syrian Democratic Forces.
- SDF was created in 2015 by various Syrian Kurdish political forces and their military wing, the People's Protection Units (YPG), and the Women's Protection Units (YPJ).
- SDF was created as a platform for the Syrian Kurds to join with other groups into an anti-IS military alliance.
- However, Turks feel that, SDF is dominated by Syrian Kurds.



ISLAMIC STATE WAS DEFEATED IN RAQQA BY KURDS

- 1 SDF, with air support from the United States of America routed the Islamic State from Raqqa in October 2017.
- 2 After liberating Raqqa, the Kurdish leadership suggested to the people of Raqqa, that they could join the Kurdish-run Democratic Federation of Northern Syria known as Rojava.



GRAND PLAN OF KURDISTAN

- 1 The ambitions of the Kurdish population are very clear.
- 2 Attempt by Iraqi Kurds in 2017, to declare independence was curtailed by the armed intervention of Iraqi army.
- 3 Attempt by Syrian Kurds to produce a similar autonomous region in Syria-Turkish border is now opposed by Turkey.

The geopolitical calculations returned once again.



HOW THE TURKEY VIEWS KURDS?

- 1 Turkey sees all Kurdish ambitions for self-determination as an abomination.
- 2 It declared Kurdish Workers' Party (PKK), as a terrorist organisation.
- 3 The war against Turkish Kurds continues in south-eastern Turkey.

There is no one to stop the Turkish entry into Syria and no one to provide Syrian Kurds with assistance. The Turkish Air Force continues to bomb SDF positions without challenge.

WHAT IS THE TRIGGER FOR THE PRESENT DAY ATTACKS BY TURKEY AGAINST KURDISH MILITANTS IN THE BORDER TOWN OF AFRIN IN SYRIA?



- 1 U.S. announcement of plans to create a 30,000 strong Kurdish border force.
- 2 Getting the arms by YPG from the West and Turkey feels that, it may lead to strengthening of PKK in Turkey.
- 3 American support will in fact, further strengthen the Kurds in the region.

Under these circumstances, the plan is to oust the YPG guerrillas from the nearby areas of Turkey and now there is convergence of interest among Russia, Syria, Iran and Turkey.

WHAT ARE ITS REPERCUSSIONS?

- 1 If the rift between the USA and Turkey widens, the proxy battles in the Country may acquire their own momentum.
- 2 YPG proved very strong in the ground battle against IS, since 2015 and it is not easy to push over easily.
- 3 YPG has got enormous local support in Kurdish towns.
- 4 Even if Turkey ousts the YPG from Afrin, it will not ease tensions on the border.
- 5 It would drag Turkey deeper into the Syrian Conflict.
- 6 The Syria's border region likely to see more bloodshed and destruction in the coming months.



The need of the hour is all the Countries must sit together to find out solution.

WE EXPRESS OUR SINCERE THANKS FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

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